only to get an outside edge to Mark Taylor at slip. I was extremely disappointed with myself for not playing myself in and was determined to make amends in the second innings.

Our bowlers, in particular Kumble and Raju, did well to get the first eight Australian wickets for 201. It seemed we had a good chance of taking a first-innings lead, but we were frustrated when the Australian wicketkeeper Ian Healy and off-spinner Gavin Robertson, the debutant, put together a very good partnership. They added 96 runs between them, and Australia eventually gained a 71-run advantage. It seemed a crucial lead and at a dinner organized by former BCCI president AC Muthiah, Srinivas Venkataraghavan, a former India captain and leading off-spinner of the 1970s, said to me that it would be very difficult for us to get back into the match. He said that he thought there wasn't enough time left in the game to make up the deficit, set a target and finally bowl Australia out to win the match. I replied confidently that there was still plenty of time and that I was sure we would be able to turn things round.

Before the start of our second innings I remember saying in the dressing room that it was the responsibility of the batsmen to put their hands up and try to score 75 runs each for the team. You don't always need to set the bar really high and demand a hundred. I thought that scoring 75 in the second innings at Chennai would be good enough to set up the match.

When Sidhu was out for an important 64, I walked out to bat at 115–2, in effect 44–2 after deducting the deficit of 71 runs, and as on many occasions in my career I had Rahul Dravid for company in the middle. I started out watchfully and was soon into my groove. As expected, Shane Warne started to bowl round the wicket and I instantly took the attack to him and hit him over midwicket. From an individual perspective it was a defining moment in the game. We couldn't afford to lose another wicket, but we also couldn't go too much on the defensive.

Rahul and I added more than a hundred runs, to set up a strong platform. By the time Rahul was dismissed for another well-played half-century, I felt in control. I went on the attack and scored at a fair clip, hitting fours and sixes with regularity. Azhar gave me good support and we also added over a hundred runs, at almost five runs an over, a potentially match-winning partnership.

When we declared, I was not out on 155, the first-innings lead had been nullified and we were in with a great chance of winning the match,